



UNTITLED PARTY GAME

Design Document - version 0.1

An online party game show for 2-8 players, hosted by someone who watched every humiliating thing you did tonight.

STEAM / WINDOWS FIRST / ONLINE, KEYBOARD-FIRST

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The game

You and up to seven friends - each on your own PC, wherever you are - are contestants on a chaotic televised game show. You play short, silly challenges. Between them you move around a studio floor where traps, swaps and shady offers await. Presiding over all of it is a host who genuinely watched everything you did and will not let you forget it.

By round five he is running jokes about your friends that he invented himself. In the finale he pays them off. Every group's session becomes its own story, and that story is different every time because it is built from what actually happened.

Players	2-8, online. Everyone plays from their own PC, on their own screen.
Session length	15 / 30 / 45 minutes, chosen at the start
Round length	30-60 seconds per minigame
Platform	Steam, Windows primary
Networking	Steam P2P (Lobbies + SteamNetworkingSockets). Host-authoritative. Free relay and friend invites - no servers to run, no hosting bill.
Engine	Unity 6 LTS
Input	Keyboard first , gamepad fully supported. Two action buttons maximum.

Design principles

Principle	What it means in practice
Playable by all	Two buttons. No tutorial. A parent, a child and a drunk friend can all join round one and be competitive by round two.
The loser matters more than the winner	Every minigame needs a clear, funny, recognisable way to fail. The failure is what the host makes jokes about, and the jokes are the product.
Instantly readable	Everyone has their own screen, but shared arenas still hold up to eight characters. You must know who just died without reading a name.
The game survives without the AI	Remove the host and this is still a working party game. The AI adds identity, not function. This is deliberate and non-negotiable.
Fun is discovered, not assumed	Twelve minigames are designed; roughly four are expected to be cut after playtesting. That is the plan, not a failure.

Look and feel

The direction in one line: Saturday night television, 1979, on far too much sugar.

Everything is a garish TV studio. Chrome, chase lights, an audience in silhouette, confetti cannons that fire at the slightest excuse, and a set that is trying much harder than the budget allowed. The aesthetic is doing three jobs at once: it gives the game a distinctive identity, it justifies extremely saturated colours which is what makes eight players readable on one screen, and it is funny before anything even happens.

Practically, it is also cheap. One studio environment is reused for the entire game, redressed per minigame. There is no world to build.

Palette

Deep studio dark as the ground, with hot broadcast colours on top. High contrast everywhere - this is a game watched from a sofa, not studied up close.

STUDIO	HOT PINK	CYAN	GOLD	ORANGE	LIME	PAPER
#17123A	#FF3E9D	#00E0FF	#FFC542	#FF7A2F	#9BE84B	#F8F9F4

Player colours

One saturated colour per player, applied to the whole body. These are chosen to stay distinct at small size, in motion, and against the desaturated arenas.

P1	P2	P3	P4	P5	P6	P7	P8
#E8412E	#2F7BE8	#FFC542	#3FB950	#9B5DE5	#FF7A2F	#00E0FF	#FF3E9D

Characters

Chunky, simple, slightly wobbly. Deliberately crude silhouettes - closer to a bath toy than a person. Big eyes, almost no face. Physics-driven wobble does the acting, which means comedy comes from the simulation rather than from animation work.

Rule	Why
One bold colour per player, whole body	The single most important readability decision. You should know who died without reading a name.
A distinct silhouette prop each (hat, antenna, cone, halo)	Colour alone fails for colourblind players and in a scrum. Shape is the backup channel.
Name tag floating above, always on	Non-negotiable with eight players. Your own character also gets a highlight ring, since each player has their own view.
Arenas desaturated, players saturated	Characters must pop off the background at all times.
Camera always frames every living player	Rendered per client, so it can also favour YOUR character slightly. If someone cannot see themselves, they are not playing.

The set

A single television studio, redressed per challenge. Raised stage, chase lights around the edge, chrome trim, a giant scoreboard, and an audience rendered as silhouettes that react - standing up, throwing things, going silent at the right moment.

The host appears on a giant studio screen above the stage. This is a deliberate production decision as much as an artistic one: a screen is far cheaper than a fully animated character, it is completely diegetic for a game show, and it means his presence can be upgraded later - a face, then a body, then a character who walks onto the set - without redesigning anything.

Interface

Television broadcast language, not video game language. Lower thirds, score bugs, big chunky numbers that slam onto screen, wipe transitions between rounds. The UI should look like it is being cut live by a director who is slightly panicking.

Element	Treatment
Scores	Broadcast score bug, bottom of screen, always visible, player colours
Round titles	Full-screen slam card with the challenge name before each minigame
Host lines	Lower third under the studio screen, with the line also spoken aloud
Eliminations	Instant, loud, and funny - a stamp, a buzzer, confetti of the wrong colour
Board	Seen from above like a studio floor plan, pieces are the characters themselves

Audio

Audio carries more of a party game than art does, and costs a fraction as much. A brass sting for wins, a descending trombone for failures, a live studio audience that gasps and jeers, and cheap chase music that never quite stops. The host is voiced - a read host is a fraction as good as a heard one, and delivery is most of the comedy.

Open question, deliberately unresolved: whether the game is 3D or 2D. Everything above works in either. A 2D or 2.5D treatment would cut art cost enormously, iterate far faster, and run on almost any machine - and Pico Park, Duck Game and Ultimate Chicken Horse are proof that it costs nothing that matters.

How a session flows

#	Beat	Time	What happens
1	Sign in	2 min	Everyone picks a colour and types a name. The host uses these names constantly, so this is the only setup that matters.
2	Host intro	15 sec	The challenge is announced, framed by where everyone currently stands.
3	Minigame	30-60 sec	Everyone plays. Clear winner, clearer loser.
4	Host reaction	10 sec	The moment the game exists for. He names what actually happened and ties it to the night's running jokes.
5	Board move	20 sec	Placement decides how far you move. Landing somewhere triggers something.
6			Repeat 2-5 for roughly eight rounds.
7	The finale	2 min	Double points and a comeback mechanic, so nobody is mathematically dead early.
8	Wrap-up	1 min	The host crowns a winner and hands out titles he invented himself. This is the part people screenshot.

The board - the studio floor

A small loop, quick to move around, dense with interaction. Its job is not to be a board game; its job is to create sabotage, comebacks and grudges between minigames.

Space	Effect
Prize	Points.
Trap	Lose points, or carry a handicap into the next challenge.
Swap	Trade board positions with any player. Creates instant enemies.
Sabotage	Place a trap on the board for somebody else to find later.
Audience Vote	Everyone votes. The winner of the vote is punished.
The Host's Office	The host offers you a personal deal, built from your actual night. This is the space where the AI stops being decoration.

The host

He is the reason this game is not interchangeable with any other party game. He receives the real state of the show - standings, what just happened, the full history of the night - and speaks two sentences. He remembers everything.

The examples below are unedited output from the working prototype, not concept writing.

Round one

Ravi, the zen master of Plank Panic! Who knew standing still was the winning strategy?

Round three - a pattern forms on its own

Priya, you're redefining the term 'aquatics event' this evening! Round three was meant to be about buckets, not synchronised swimming.

The Host's Office - a deal built from her actual night

Priya, my frequent moat diver, I've got a deal sweeter than the cake you never reached. How about triple points - if you can avoid water-based humiliation in the next round? Do we have a splash-free agreement?

That offer references two separate failures and a third unrelated one, proposes a concrete trade with real risk, and asks her to accept. No scripted game can make it, because no scripted game knows her night went that way.

Two rules that make it work

Rule	Reason
Two sentences maximum	A host who rambles kills the pace of a party. Brevity is enforced in the prompt and tested.
Lines are generated during the previous minigame	The outcome of a round is knowable a beat before it ends. Waiting five seconds for a response while four people stare at a screen is fatal, so the line is always ready before it is needed. This is built and not optional.

Where he goes next

The host is designed to be promoted over time, on top of a game that already works without him.

Version	The host is...	Risk if it fails
1.0	A narrator with memory. Pure flavour.	None - cut him, the game still ships
1.x	Running show events; can favour or punish players	Low
2.0	Bargainable - argue, flatter or bribe him for advantage	Medium
3.0	A genuine opponent and character in his own right	The long-term ambition

The twelve minigames

Twelve are designed; roughly eight are expected to ship. They are grouped into five families that share a character controller, arena and camera - so the fourth game in a family costs a fraction of the first. That is what makes twelve achievable, and it is why cutting a weak one costs almost nothing.

Every entry lists its **signature humiliation**: the specific, recognisable way you fail. That is what the host builds running jokes from.

A. ARENA shared: physics character, platform, shove			
Game	Controls	Rule	Signature humiliation
1. Plank Panic	Move + Shove	A narrow plank over a long drop. Last one standing wins.	<i>Falling off in the first two seconds, having touched nobody.</i>
2. Sumo Circle	Move + Charge	The platform shrinks every ten seconds. Barge people off.	<i>Knocking yourself off with your own charge.</i>
3. Vanishing Floor	Move + Jump	Tiles drop away in waves. Be standing on something.	<i>Sprinting confidently onto the exact tile about to go.</i>
4. The Rising Room	Move + Jump	The floor rises toward a spiked ceiling. Climb over each other.	<i>Being used as a step-ladder by a friend.</i>
B. DODGE shared: overhead spawner, falling objects			
Game	Controls	Rule	Signature humiliation
5. Bucket Roulette	Move only	Buckets rain down. Most are harmless. Some are not.	<i>Standing perfectly still in the one fatal spot.</i>
6. Sticky Fingers	Move + Grab	Grab falling prizes for points. Some are bombs. Greed is punished.	<i>Catching three bombs in a row while everyone else scores.</i>
C. RACE shared: track, obstacles, bump			
Game	Controls	Rule	Signature humiliation
7. Cake Sprint	Move + Balance	Carry a wobbling cake to the finish. Any bump and it goes everywhere.	<i>Dropping it on the finish line.</i>
8. Greased Ladder	Move + Grab	Climb a slippery ladder. Others can grab your ankles.	<i>Being dragged from first to last in the final second.</i>
D. HOST-DRIVEN minimal art, maximum host - build these first			
Game	Controls	Rule	Signature humiliation
9. Red Light, Barnaby	Move only	The host calls GO and STOP. He is biased, and he lies. He will let a favourite creep forward and call you out unfairly, because he remembers who annoyed him.	<i>Being eliminated by a host who is openly cheating against you.</i>
10. Say What He Says	Two buttons	The host issues escalating silly instructions, generated live and referencing your night. Perform them in order.	<i>Confidently performing the sequence from two rounds ago.</i>
11. The Prediction	Menu select	Everyone secretly bets on who will come last in the NEXT minigame. Creates table talk, alliances and betrayal between rounds.	<i>Everyone unanimously betting against one person, who then wins.</i>
E. CHAOS shared: passable object, hidden timer			

Game	Controls	Rule	Signature humiliation
12. Live Grenade	Move + Throw	Pass the parcel with a timer nobody can see.	<i>Accepting it with two seconds left because somebody lied to you.</i>

Build order: Family D first. Those three need almost no art, they prove the host as a mechanic rather than decoration, and if the host is not fun there we learn it for almost nothing. Then Family A, which unlocks four games from one controller and arena.

Controls

Keyboard first. Most people on Steam play with a keyboard, and everyone is on their own machine, so keyboard is the primary input and gamepad is a fully supported alternative - not the other way round.

Two action buttons. That is the entire scheme, and it is a hard rule. Every minigame maps onto the same handful of inputs, so nobody is ever taught anything twice and a player joining at round four is not at a disadvantage.

Action	Keyboard	Gamepad	Notes
Move	WASD or Arrows	Left stick / D-pad	The only movement input. No sprint, no crouch, no camera control.
Primary	Space	A	Context-sensitive: jump, shove, grab, throw. Always the 'do the thing' key.
Secondary	Shift or E	B	Used in roughly half the minigames: charge, balance, drop. Never required to win.
Menu / vote	1-4 or Arrows + Enter	Face buttons	Board choices, deals, and The Prediction.
Pause	Esc	Start	Votes to pause, since nobody is in the same room.

Both schemes are rebindable, and the game never mixes them - you pick one at the lobby and the on-screen prompts match what you are holding.

Rule	Reason
No combos, no holds, no timing windows tighter than about a third of a second	Anyone should be able to join and compete immediately. Precision is the enemy of a party game, and it is also the first thing that breaks over a network.
Every minigame is playable with movement alone at a basic level	Buttons add expression, never the ability to participate.
Two hands, no chords	One hand on movement, one on the action keys. Nothing requires reaching across the keyboard.
Drop-in and drop-out between rounds	People arrive late to parties. The host will absolutely comment on it.

How a game is joined

Friends-first, deliberately. This is a game you play with people you know, so the flow is built around invites rather than public matchmaking - which also avoids the empty-lobby problem that kills small online games.

Step	What happens
1. One player opens a show	Creates a Steam lobby. They become the host machine.
2. Invite	Steam friend invite, or a short join code for people not on your friends list.
3. Lobby	Pick colour and name, choose keyboard or gamepad, see who else is in. The host picks show length. The AI host warms up the crowd while you wait.
4. Play	2-8 players. Late joiners can drop in between rounds.

Modes

Mode	How it plays
Party	3-8 players online, rotating through the board and challenges, eight rounds, highest total wins.
Teams	Two teams. Voice chat naturally splits the room into conspiracies, which is the point.
Solo / Career	Climb the show's ladder against AI contestants, with the host taking a progressively greater interest in you as you win. This is also where he can later become a real character - first favouring you, then resenting you.

Platform, technology and open questions

Item	Decision
Engine	Unity 6 LTS
Target	Steam, Windows primary
Networking	Steam P2P. Steam Lobbies for invites and discovery, SteamNetworkingSockets for transport. Valve provides NAT punching and relay free , so there are no servers to run and no hosting bill. Likely stack: Mirror or Unity Netcode for GameObjects over a Steam transport.
Netcode model	Host-authoritative. One player's machine is the truth; everyone else sends inputs and receives state. Short rounds and forgiving physics make this the easy case - and a hiccup in a party game is funny rather than fatal.
Player count	2-8. Designed around friend invites, not public matchmaking.
Development machine	Editor work on a MacBook; Windows builds tested on the Windows laptop, which is the actual Steam target.
AI service	The host runs against a language model through a local service. The API key never ships inside the game binary.
Steam AI disclosure	Mandatory and will be complied with. Under Valve's January 2026 rules the host is 'live-generated content' and must be declared. The store page sells the party game; the disclosure field states the truth plainly. Both are honest.

Deliberately open

Question	Position
2D or 3D?	Genuinely undecided. The 3D requirement is inherited from an earlier, abandoned concept and may not deserve to survive. 2D would cut art cost enormously, iterate far faster and run anywhere.
The name	Not chosen. The trademark and collision check happens BEFORE any art is commissioned.
The host's voice	Text-to-speech provider undecided. This is the one place worth spending AI budget - delivery is most of the comedy.
The board's exact shape	Loop, ladder or bracket. To be resolved in prototyping.
Which four minigames get cut	Answered by playtesting, not by argument.

Design correction, August 2026: an earlier draft planned same-screen local play with Steam Remote Play Together supplying the online. That was wrong. Remote Play Together merges every keyboard into a single input stream, so it supports exactly ONE keyboard player - everyone else needs a gamepad. Since most people on Steam play with a keyboard and nobody is sitting in the same room, the game is online from the start and keyboard-first. Every reference title - Fall Guys, Gang Beasts, Pummel Party, Pico Park - is online for the same reason.

What is already proven

The host works. It is built, running, and the lines quoted in section 04 are real output rather than aspiration. Everything else in this document is a party game constructed around it - and, deliberately, one that still works if the host were removed entirely.

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